

BRINGING A NEW LEASE OF LIFE TO CANCER PATIENTS

The team performing IORT for breast cancer treatment

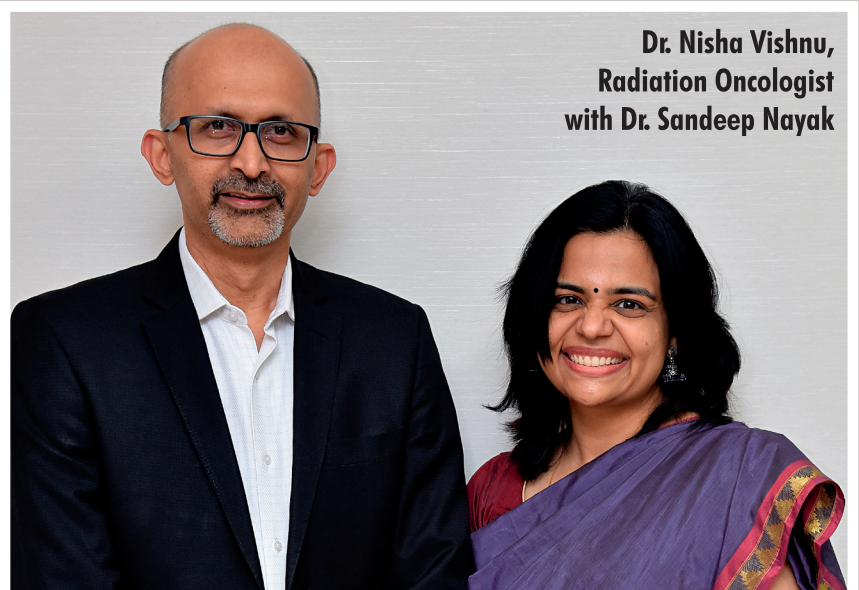
Dr. Sandeep Nayak's MACS Clinic at Bangalore has revolutionized the treatment of Cancer in the country. The efforts made to make the treatment bearable and affordable is path breaking. It has humaneness written all over it.

Hailing from a middle class family in Mangalore, Sandeep is steeped in the gentle, courteous traditions of the land. Ambitious to the core and the determination to work for it has ensured that he has emerged as India's finest oncologist.

After completing his MBBS from Kasturba Medical College he went on to do his post-graduation in General Surgery from Government Medical College, Calicut. He pursued doctoral studies in Surgical Oncology from the Chittaranjan National Cancer Institute, Kolkata. This was further complemented by a Fellowship in Laparoscopic and Robotic Onco-Surgery.

Medicine is an evolving field and needs to be updated constantly to provide better care for the patients. Dr Nayak has explored and developed newer treatment options for cancer patients as he trained and refined his skills. This led to the development by Dr Nayak of techniques like RABIT for robotic thyroid surgery and minimally invasive neck dissection (MIND) for oral cancer which are well known around the world. He also pioneered the techniques of robotic intersphincteric resection (ISR) for cancer of rectum by which a surgeon is able to save nearly 80% of patients from permanent stoma, robotic 3 field esophagectomy and many such techniques to help maximum number of patients. He leads a team of doctors who are committed to provide cancer patients with the best solutions. He has been in the forefront in using cutting-edge technologies like Laparoscopic and Robotic surgery.

Breast cancer is the most common cancer among Indian women. Losing breast has a major psychological impact on a woman. However, today it is possible to save breast among most of the women using various advanced solutions. Despite this many women cannot opt for breast saving surgery for logistic reason. This is so for many ladies above 50 years of age who find it difficult to take radiotherapy after lumpectomy, which is a surgery to remove the cancer tumour alone. The conventional radiotherapy takes 30-40 days to complete. The time and effort to visit the hospital every day for that long drains the patient as well as the caregiver. There is a loss of time and a financial drain. There is a technology to solve this problem. Intraoperative radiotherapy (IORT) using Intrabeam® device for breast cancer can deliver this radiation in 30



**Dr. Nisha Vishnu,
Radiation Oncologist
with Dr. Sandeep Nayak**

mins, effectively saving time and money for the patient as well as the caregiver. There are more than 250 running IORT machines all over the world, however, there is only one centre offering this facility in South Asia, which is Fortis Cancer Institute, Bangalore which is headed by Dr Nayak. Now it is possible for breast cancer patients in this region to opt for IORT and complete their breast cancer treatment in one single day effectively completing **30 days of treatment in 30 min.**

Focussing on early recovery from treatment of cancer has been the key aim of the team that Dr. Nayak has developed over the years. The team has focussed on using minimally invasive surgery which includes robotic and laparoscopic surgery to make cancer treatment less traumatic. In achieving this many new surgical techniques had to be innovated and many technologies had to be adopted. We notice that Dr. Nayak believes in treating the patient, not the disease. Many times what is right for the disease may not be what is right for the patient. The art of making it precise for the patient is very important. Treatment needs to be adaptable yet effective.

The best results are achieved only when every effort is made to make the treatment customised for the patient. With an excellent team of experts like Dr Nisha Vishnu, a radiation oncologist and Dr Suresh Babu a medical oncologist, the MACS team runs a very ethical practice since 2013. Over time, their exceptional work has made them popular across India and many parts of the world. MACS clinic is associated with multiple hospitals to provide equitable care for patients from different economic strata.

Dr. Nayak has also started an NGO called Samrohana. A non-governmental not for profit organization, it is engaged in prevention and early detection of cancer. It provides care, counselling and rehabilitation to persons fighting cancer and their families. It helps them to navigate towards wellness through various activities. Samrohana counsels, guides and educates them towards healthy living through interactive approach. It is evolving as a proactive community platform to connect, network and support patients, their caregivers, doctors and allied medical fraternity associated with cancer.